



MONTHLY UPDATE

South Africa: monthly update, July 2026

Edition of 2026-08-17 · 66 systems and instruments tracked, 20 of them not held

Developments recorded from artefacts published between 2026-07-01 and 2026-08-17 – July 2026 carried forward to the date of issue, so the report holds the nightly catch to the day it was cut. Sections follow the status report.

Summary of the month

Two spectrum instruments were gazetted, the national artificial-intelligence policy changed from a rule-making instrument to a guidance one, and the Western Cape High Court struck down part of the birth-registration regulations. On delivery, a Public Service Commission investigation found [more than R2bn in irregular expenditure](#) at the State Information Technology Agency, which was [given 30 days to produce a recovery plan](#). Operation Vulindlela's quarterly report of 31 July recorded the single citizen application at [production-ready pilot](#), dated the next milestones to September 2026 and stated that progress had been uneven.

Infrastructure

Connectivity

The [National Radio Frequency Plan 2026](#), approved by the minister on 2 July, was gazetted on 24 July and realigns the allocation table from 8.3kHz to 3,000GHz to the ITU Radio Regulations and to the SADC and African Telecommunications Union plans. The [IMT Roadmap 2026](#) was published for consultation the same day; its tables record 794MHz assigned to licensees and 18,831MHz still to be assigned. The regulator's [accompanying statement of an increase from 850MHz to at least 18,588MHz by 2030, and of a 215% rise in high-demand spectrum](#), does not appear in the gazetted text; the two accounts have not been reconciled. Allocation of the 6GHz band was [deferred pending a feasibility study](#).

Herotel, a domestic provider with more than 350,000 customers, was [named Amazon Leo's South African distributor](#) for a 2027 launch. Starlink [began service in its 27th African country](#) and remains unlicensed in South Africa; the department told Parliament its draft satellite policy direction was ["of general application and not directed at any specific operator"](#). The state-backed [BrainSAT](#) venture launched on Emirati infrastructure.

Cape Town's municipal planning tribunal [approved two Equinix data centres](#) over objections from three civil-society organisations; the application disclosed neither water nor electricity demand, both deferred to the site development plan. Reuters put the planned load at about 170MW. NTT Data South Africa confirmed it had [sold seven facilities and](#)

[leased them back](#). Google held its first African cloud summit in Johannesburg and announced an Eastern Cape exchange port; the President welcomed hyperscaler commitments while [stating that government is building its own cloud through the CSIR](#).

Technical Capacity

Parliament's science committee reported after an oversight visit that the [Centre for High Performance Computing has reached maximum capacity and that available infrastructure is insufficient for future growth](#). The centre is one of three pillars of the national cyber infrastructure system, alongside the research network and the secure national data centre, and it supports the electronic vaccination data system.

Cybersecurity

Two independent readings of the year both point at the same thing. The financial regulator's fourth regulatory actions report records [140 public warnings and R2.89bn in penalties on 76 persons for the year to March](#), most warnings concerning unregistered providers promoting investment offerings on social media and about a fifth involving impersonation of licensed institutions, the regulator and its own staff among them. [Over R2bn of that total is a single deepfake-advertising matter](#), whose debarment and penalty reconsiderations were still pending at the report date. Separately a forensics firm puts [attacker dwell time at 18 days in 2025, with some intrusions running start to finish inside a day](#), attributed to ransomware-as-a-service and automated reconnaissance. It is one firm's caseload rather than a national series, and a shorter dwell time is faster execution, not better defence.

Legislation and regulation

The Electronic Communications Amendment Bill was published, [exempting community networks from licensing](#) and mandating spectrum sharing; submissions close on 21 August.

Digital public infrastructure

Data Exchange

Two exchanges were arranged this month and neither states what happens to the data. The medicines regulator [opened a pilot inviting sponsors and investigators to report serious adverse events through an externally hosted module](#), routing South African clinical-trial safety data through infrastructure hosted by the WHO's Uppsala centre and adopting its reporting standard rather than a domestic one; no pilot duration, participant target, data-residency statement or transition date to mandatory reporting is published. The revenue service [signed an implementation arrangement with Malawi's revenue authority for a secure platform exchanging customs information in real time](#), aligned to the World Customs Organisation data model and operationalising a mutual assistance agreement negotiated in 2019. No go-live date is stated, and no purpose-limitation, retention or reciprocity terms are published.

Digital Identity and CRVS

Absa [joined the bank-branch smart identity channel](#), which the department put at 296 branches and more than 385,000 applications in four months; Operation Vulindlela's quarterly report [gave 203,887 applications across 171 branches](#). The reference periods differ and the figures have not been reconciled. Mobile operators and the justice department agreed a framework to [replace document presentation in SIM registration with real-time departmental verification](#).

On 29 July the Western Cape High Court [held four categories of exclusion in the birth-registration regulations unconstitutional](#), allowing 18 months for amendment and holding that the orders required no Constitutional Court confirmation.

Home Affairs reported that its electronic travel authorisation had [refused more than 5,500 travellers](#) since October 2025. It then left the pilot: the system [went live at OR Tambo, Cape Town, King Shaka and Lanseria from 12 August, with 6,126 fraudulent applications rejected – put at 2.8% of pilot submissions – and full visa-type rollout targeted by year-end](#). The department publishes no statistical series, and the four rejection counts it has given this year rest on bases that do not reconcile.

Digital Payments and Fintech

Operation Vulindlela's quarterly report of 31 July recorded the Payments Ecosystem Modernisation programme moving beyond conceptual design into active development of a payment credential, wallet, governance and trust capabilities, with testing against government use cases dated November 2026. Nothing held states how that rail relates to the bank-API rails below.

The Reserve Bank gazetted a [national interoperable payment code standard](#), with PayShap the first rail to adopt it. Ozow launched a shared [bank application-programming-interface rail with FNB and RMB](#), its fourth such arrangement, and Pepkor announced a [R21.3bn merger of Flash and Shop2Shop](#), subject to approval.

Registries (population, land, address, etc.)

Home Affairs reported [377,060 identity numbers still blocked](#) and stated it could not trace approximately 400,000 of those affected, against a court deadline extended to March 2027.

Sectoral management information systems (HMIS, EMIS, etc.)

The student funding scheme's administrator submitted a stabilisation plan stating that [ICT is the scheme's biggest operational risk, fragmented, manual and not fit for purpose](#). The same submission reports 66 major audit findings and a disclaimer audit opinion from the Auditor-General, 115 overdue internal audit findings and nine material irregularities, five of them data or systems defects. The scheme was placed under administration in May and its governance failures referred to the Special Investigating Unit.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

Operation Vulindlela's quarterly report of 31 July recorded an update under way to the [Minimum Interoperability Standards and the Government-Wide Enterprise Architecture](#), with an update due September 2026.

On 3 August the single citizen application was reported as a [production-ready pilot](#), its first credential use case a digital matric certificate built with Umalusi, with the verification approach in testing.

Governance and regulation

Legislation and regulation

The minister [backed the regulator](#) in the review application brought by the two largest mobile operators against the data bundle roll-over rules. The Angolan kwanza became the [second settlement currency on the SADC real-time system](#), the first addition since 2013.

Strategies, plans and policies

The state put two studies out to tender and conceded the gap they are meant to fill. The communications department's market-analysis tender [concedes a current policy vacuum and that the price benefits expected from the 2022 spectrum auction remain largely unmet](#), naming market concentration, spectrum allocation and the burden on prepaid consumers as structural causes; its deliverables are a cost-to-communicate roadmap and an assessment of progress on the 2019 data-services market inquiry recommendations. A second tender [seeks an ICT-indicators and scenario-modelling system to steer the digital economy to 2050](#), with no award, value or delivery date. Against both, the reform programme's quarterly report [concedes progress has been uneven and in certain instances slower than initially anticipated](#), against the 80% on-track figure that remains its dated prior.

Standards

Parliament's communications committee [prefers strengthening the existing regulators through the ICT and media regulators forum to creating the four artificial-intelligence bodies the withdrawn draft policy proposed](#). The forum was launched in 2024 and no instrument establishing its powers is held.

Data protection

The data-protection statute has been enforceable since 2021 and operates as an adequacy model rather than hard localisation: [cross-border transfers are permitted where equivalent protection, consent or contractual necessity applies, with the controller accountable](#). The [maximum fine is R10m against a measured average breach cost of R44.1m](#) — the penalty is a fraction of the harm it is meant to deter.

Artificial intelligence and the technology sector

Strategies, plans and policies

The Department of Communications and Digital Technologies stated on 29 July that the redrafted national AI policy [will issue guidelines rather than prescribe rules](#), and that the seven institutions proposed in the withdrawn draft are being reconsidered; cabinet consideration is targeted for November 2026, with January 2027 as fallback. On 31 July the chair of Parliament's communications portfolio committee stated her [opposition to creating new AI regulators](#).

Standards

The Prudential Authority's 2025/26 report, reported on 16 July, [embeds AI, cloud, cyber and data-offshoring into bank supervision](#) and records a first nationwide AI-adoption survey naming regulatory uncertainty, AI skills and governance as the barriers. A dedicated framework is expected in 2026; none is published.

AI

The Labour Court [stayed disciplinary proceedings](#) against three municipal employees on prima facie evidence that a ruling relied on authorities that do not exist. SARS disclosed that [100% of verification cases and 88.41% of complex audits](#) are selected by automated risk assessment. Huawei reported [1,400 local partners accounting for 94.7% of its local revenue](#) at its Sandton partner event, where South Africa's founding membership of the China-led World AI Cooperation Organisation was noted; the figures are company-reported.

The measured incidence of AI-enabled harm remains low and the reason is contested. An analysis of an incident database published on 14 August [links South Africa to 12 of more than 1,600 recorded global cases through April 2026](#), attributing the low count to public wariness rather than to strong defences, against deepfake, fabricated-citation and biometric-verification incidents already on record. It is a count of *recorded* cases, and no national reporting duty exists that would make the denominator meaningful.

ICT Industry

The sector's transformation body lost its chair. The communications minister [replaced the B-BBEE ICT Sector Council's chairperson and appointed an interim chair for six months](#) on 14 August, after a departmental investigation found the council dysfunctional. The investigation report is not published, and no remedial plan, terms of reference for the interim period or date for a permanent appointment is stated.

Inclusion and capacity

Access to services

The South African Social Security Agency [set 350,000 grant reviews for 2026/27](#) against a projected R1.5bn saving, while beneficiaries flagged from September 2025 [reported continued non-payment](#). An account of the digitalised grants system published on 25 July set out the [bank-account means test applied across eight grants](#), which remains in operation under appeal, with the Supreme Court of Appeal hearing set for 25 August 2026. Gold Cards were confirmed to [cease functioning after 31 August](#); the position of beneficiaries who miss the deadline was not stated.

Training and skills

The information technology sector education and training authority was [referred for a governance assessment](#).

The pipeline that authority sits in was reviewed on 14 August. A development bank's report with the higher education department, philanthropically funded, finds [the route from school through universities and technical colleges into employment constrained at both ends](#) — young people arriving without the foundational digital skills

the workplace needs, and employers unable to fill digital vacancies alongside high unemployment. Its finding is that the mismatch is structural and will not correct itself. That is a verdict on the strategy already under review on this ledger rather than a new instrument.

Finance

New investments

One programme opened in the window, and it is not yet a commitment to anybody. On 11 August the United Kingdom published an expression-of-interest call for a Southern Africa science and technology accelerator worth up to GBP2.5m over three years to March 2030, with up to GBP400,000 for 2026/27, covering artificial intelligence and emerging technologies and digital access alongside climate, energy, health and space. South Africa is the primary focus and Zimbabwe and Zambia the first year's. The fund is resourced and the delivery consortium is not chosen, so what the money buys is a matter for a contract expected later in the year.

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